

YOUR MINI COLLECTION READY TO SELL™

Small-Batch Production

Layer cutting, chain sewing and your first batch of 10 pieces.

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PART 1

From one piece to a batch

What changes when you make 10 identical pieces.

Made-to-measure means making a different garment for each client. A batch means making several identical pieces at once: you cut once, sew in a production line and repeat the same steps. Each piece takes less time.

	MADE TO MEASURE	IN A BATCH
Measurements	Each client's	The sizes you choose for the batch
Cutting	One piece at a time	Several layers at once
Sewing	Every step of one garment	One step on every garment, then the next
Selling	Sell first, then make	Make first, then sell

Start with the simplest

For your first batch, choose knickers, bralettes or bodysuits: small pieces in stretch fabric that forgive small differences. Leave the corset, which is more demanding, until you've had some practice.

PART 2

Choosing what to produce

A batch that will sell.

Your first batch

- ☐ A single style (or two very similar ones).
- ☐ What your clients ask for most: check your messages and your client profiles.
- ☐ Two or three sizes, no more (for example small, medium and large, based on your clients).
- ☐ One colour, or two colours that go together.
- ☐ 10 pieces in total, split according to the sizes you're asked for most.

Sizing the batch

Look at your client profiles and group them into 2 or 3 similar groups. Grade the pattern to the middle measurement of each group (with the “How to Adapt the Pattern” guide if you have it) and make a sample of each before cutting the batch.

PART 3

Layer cutting

Cutting several pieces at once.

- 1 Work out the fabric: lay the pattern on the fabric to see how much one piece takes and multiply by the pieces in the batch, plus 10%.
- 2 Spread the fabric in layers (2 to 4 to start with), all right side the same way and on grain.
- 3 Hold the layers with pattern weights or pins so they don't shift.
- 4 Place all the pattern pieces as tightly as possible, respecting the grain.
- 5 Cut with a rotary cutter or very sharp scissors, without lifting the layers.
- 6 Mark the notches on all layers at once.
- 7 Bundle the pieces by garment and size, with a label on each bundle.

Stretch fabric

Stretch fabric shifts when cut in layers. Use fewer layers (2) and weights instead of pins.

PART 4

Chain sewing

One step on every piece.

- 1 List the sewing steps for the garment (for example: side seams, waist elastic, leg elastic, gusset, finishing).
- 2 Do step 1 on every piece, one after another, without cutting the thread between them.
- 3 Snip the threads joining the pieces and move on to step 2.
- 4 Press them all together when needed.
- 5 Leave the hand finishing until the end, all together.

Your step sheet

STEP	WHAT	MACHINE	DONE (10)
1			□□□□□□□□□□
2			□□□□□□□□□□
3			□□□□□□□□□□
4			□□□□□□□□□□
5			□□□□□□□□□□
6			□□□□□□□□□□
7			□□□□□□□□□□
8			□□□□□□□□□□

PART 5

Quality control

No piece goes out unchecked.

Every piece

- ☐ Even seams, no skipped stitches.
- ☐ Elastic without ripples or loose sections.
- ☐ Threads trimmed.
- ☐ Measurements as planned (measure 3 at random, in cm or inches).
- ☐ Label with the size.
- ☐ Pressed and folded the same as the others.

PART 6

Batch cost and price

So you don't lose money on the batch.

- 1 Add up all the fabric and supplies for the batch.
- 2 Add up the hours for the whole batch (cutting + sewing + finishing + checking).
- 3 Divide by the number of pieces: that's the cost per piece.
- 4 Work out the price per piece with your profit.
- 5 Think about the sale-or-return price (see "Selling at Markets, Pop-Ups and Lingerie Boutiques"): the shop keeps a share.

Important

This guide helps you organise your work; it is not a promise of income. Results depend on your practice, your costs, your prices and your clients' demand.

Next step

Choose the style and sizes for your first batch and work out how much fabric you need.